

A Strong HAND

Firmness and vision are what young Indians need. It's been 25 years since Indira Gandhi was killed but her shadow still looms large.

Who do you think has been the best leader India has seen so far?



Indira Gandhi	19
A.P.J. Abdul Kalam	15
Narendra Modi	12
Atal Bihari Vajpayee	11
Manmohan Singh	10
Rajiv Gandhi	9
Sonia Gandhi	7
Jawaharlal Nehru	4
L.K. Advani	3
Sardar Patel	2
Lalu Prasad Yadav	2
Mayawati	2
P. Chidambaram	2

All figures in per cent. Rest: Don't know/Can't say

More than half of young India wants to vote but 20 per cent feel that not many options are available to them. For 12 per cent, the lack of a voter ID card is a big hurdle.

79% say that there is little access to information on candidates

98 per cent in Chennai want more information on the voting process to propel them into booths

84% of young Indians would reject candidates with criminal records

Over 60 per cent of young Indians says that voters should have the right to recall an elected official if he or she is a non-performer

Family but the official prime ministerial candidate of his own party. Manmohan Singh, the original economic wunderkind, comes at the fourth position. The youth have chosen a leader who delivers, a leader who has found redemption in the hard work of reform. They have chosen the doer and rejected the wafflers.

Modi, the prime minister the young India is waiting for, is also the third best leader the country has seen, below Indira Gandhi and A.P.J. Abdul Kalam but above Nehru, Patel, Vajpayee and Advani. Mrs G at No 1 means the youth prefers a Leader with a Capital L—strong,

charismatic, and someone with enough iron in the soul. They badly miss a leader who dares. They are not obviously looking for the Perfect One, oozing garden-variety moral virtues. Mrs G, after all, had never been perfect. Her totalitarian temptations and her political paranoia are parts of our national narrative. Modi too is not a perfect model; there is a dash of the dictatorial about him, an exaggerated notion of his own indispensability. Maybe for his admirers that is a manifestation of his confidence and conviction. We can't miss the trait that unites the two strong leaders who concentrate the mind of

75% would vote for a citizen with a clean record, but 40 per cent in Ahmedabad would vote for a politician irrespective of his criminal background